Episode 4

The Rubber Plantation

ចំការកៅស៊ូ

Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Colonial rubber estate and processing cellars, Kampong Cham Province
In-story time	Dense midnight fog · 11:30 PM – 4:00 AM
Playtime	3 – 4 hours
Seal	#4 · The Iron Tapping Knife
Version	2.0 · October 2026 · Draft for review

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01 Episode Overview

The colonial rubber stamp leads Sora east to a vast plantation in Kampong Cham, swallowed by an unnatural fog. In the endless rows of trees, spirits call her name in the voices of the people she loves. In the abandoned manor, she finally learns the full truth of what her great-grandfather signed.

LOCATION **Kampong Cham** Rubber estate, manor, factory	WEATHER **Dense fog** Visibility 3–4 metres	PLAYTIME **3 – 4 hours** 3 acts
CORE MECHANIC **Navigation and taboo** Compass, grid map, "don't look back"	ENTITIES **Khmaoch Prey · Neak Ta** Voice mimics · fog stalker	SEAL **#4 Iron Tapping Knife** Melted in the furnace

1.1 Episode goal

Cross the fog-bound rubber grid to the colonial manor, uncover the original contract, open the factory cellars and melt the **Iron Tapping Knife** (Seal #4) in the coal furnace.

1.2 Role in the series

Introduces	The hand-held compass, grid-map navigation, the fog loop, the voice-mimic taboo, the gear and valve puzzle, the furnace defence and crawling through tight spaces.
Reveals	The full truth: in 1910, during famine and cholera, Sora's great-grandfather, a labour supervisor on the estate, signed a blood contract with the Neak Ta, pledging his bloodline for four generations. Uncle Sok came here in 1928 to burn the contract ledger and failed.
Leads to	The molten ingot fuses the blood lines on the map into one path to Phnom Kulen, the setting of Episode 5.

1.3 Visual identity

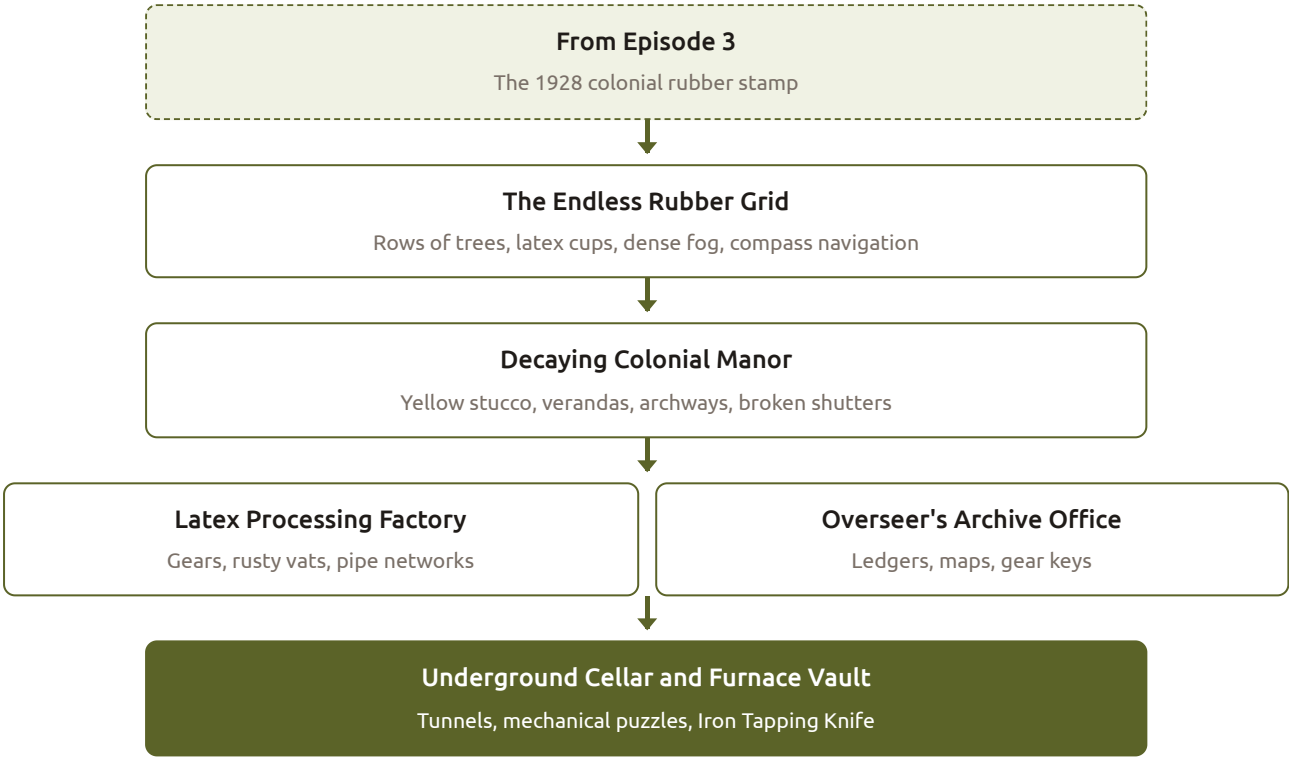
Dense grey volumetric fog, muted olive green, rusty iron orange, decaying yellow French stucco, brown dirt trails, and the warm amber sphere of lantern light.

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora ស្រ៉ា	Protagonist	Now uncovering the deep historical roots of the curse. She relies on her compass, her map-drawing skill and her hearing to cross the disorienting grid of trees.	Player character.
Overseer Jean-Luc in letters and ledgers	Historical witness	A long-dead French plantation manager. His archived ledgers and journals describe the forced labour conditions and the contract signed by Sora's great-grandfather.	Lore source; key clues for the manor and factory.
Khmaoch Prey ខ្មោចព្រៃ	Enemies	Tall, slender, disfigured forest spirits living among the rubber trees. They imitate familiar voices, calling Sora's name as her grandmother, Uncle Sok or dead relatives, to lure her off the safe paths.	Taboo enemies: never answer, never turn around.
The Neak Ta shadow អ្នកតា	Antagonist	An inescapable dark presence weaving through the fog, trying to crush Sora's lantern and break her sense of direction.	Pressure in the grid; boss-like force in the cellar.

03 Locations and Layout

3.1 Progression map



3.2 Area details

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
The Rubber Grid ចំការកៅស៊ូ	Hundreds of tall, perfectly straight rubber trees in rigid rows. Each trunk has diagonal spiral tapping cuts and a small rusted clay cup collecting latex. Tapper stations hold small oil cans.	Thick ground fog limits visibility to 3–4 m; the lantern makes a soft amber sphere full of drifting fog particles	Navigation, voice-mimic taboo, fuel collection
Colonial Manor ផ្ទះបារាំង	A two-storey French-colonial mansion with peeling yellow stucco, arched verandas, wrought-iron balconies and collapsed tiled roofs overgrown with vines. Inside: dusty gramophones, broken ceiling fans, overturned rattan armchairs, antique safes, faded French maps of Kampong Cham.	Fog-filtered moonlight, lantern	Lore, evasion, gear search

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
Factory and Cellars	Large brick and corrugated-iron processing sheds connected to a network of concrete cellars. Rusted latex vats, iron pressure valves, heavy gear assemblies, overhead conveyor rails and an industrial coal furnace.	Furnace glow, rusted wall braziers	Gear puzzle, furnace ritual, escape

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Act I · The Grid of Voices

Playtime 0:00 – 1:00 · Story 11:30 PM – 12:30 AM

NARRATIVE

Sora reaches the edge of the vast Kampong Cham (កំពង់ចាម) estate late at night. An unnatural fog has smothered the region and hidden the moon. With a brass compass and her oil lantern, she enters the grid of rubber trees to find the abandoned manor.

In the silence, soft voices begin to drift through the fog. Her grandmother calls: *"Sora… over here… I'm lost in the trees…"* Then Uncle Sok's voice calls from another direction.

Sora remembers a taboo her elders taught her:

> *If you hear a voice calling your name in the dark forest at night, never answer, and never turn around.*
>
> Khmer folk taboo

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Compass and map navigation	The player holds a brass compass and follows Sora's hand-drawn grid map between numbered tree rows. Wrong turns quietly loop back in the fog.
"Don't look back" taboo	When a Khmaoch Prey speaks in a familiar voice behind Sora, a distinct sound cue plays. The player must keep walking forward without turning the camera or making a sound until the voice fades.
Lantern fuel	The lantern burns oil faster in the dense fog. Small oil cans hang at tapper stations throughout the grid.

Act II · Secrets of the Manor

Playtime 1:00 – 2:30 · Story 12:30 – 2:30 AM

NARRATIVE

Sora escapes the grid and reaches the overgrown manor. Inside, she searches Overseer Jean-Luc's archived letters and the estate ledgers from 1910.

There she finds the dark truth of her family line. During a devastating famine and cholera outbreak in 1910, her great-grandfather was a labour supervisor on this estate. To save his dying family and secure wealth, he signed a **blood contract** with the ancient land guardian, pledging the spiritual devotion and freedom of his bloodline for four generations. Uncle Sok came here in 1928 to burn the original contract ledger but was driven out by the entities guarding the cellar.

To reach the cellar vault where the contract's tool is kept, Sora must solve the gear puzzle in the factory shed.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Factory gears and pipes	Study French mechanical drawings copied into the sketchbook, collect three missing iron gears from the manor and set the boiler's pressure valves to open the heavy cellar doors (see section 6.1).
Indoor evasion	Move through dark, creaking corridors while avoiding shadow shapes lurking in window frames and wardrobes.

Act III · The Furnace Vault and Seal #4

Playtime 2:30 – 3:30 · Story 2:30 – 4:00 AM

NARRATIVE

Sora descends into the latex cellars beneath the factory. The air is thick with the smell of old sulphur and dried latex. In the deepest chamber, resting in the frame of an open coal furnace, she finds the fourth seal: an **Iron Tapping Knife** crusted with dried blood and engraved with binding runes.

As she lifts it, the Neak Ta manifests in full physical force, blocking the cellar exit with towering shadow tendrils as the steam pipes burst around her.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Smelting ritual	Load coal into the furnace and light it with matches. Place the knife in the crucible and work the bellows until the metal melts completely.
Pressure defence	While the knife melts, manage the steam valves to keep the shadows back and keep the lantern lit, under intense spatial audio.
Ventilation escape	As the knife melts, the seal breaks with a supernatural shockwave that collapses the cellar stairs. Sora crawls through a collapsing concrete ventilation tunnel to the surface.

Resolution and Cliffhanger

Story 4:00 AM

Sora crawls out of the ventilation shaft into damp grass as the fog begins to lift at **4:00 AM**. In her hand is the molten silver-iron ingot from the furnace.

When she opens her sketchbook, the ingot reacts with the paper: the blood lines on the map fuse into one, pointing far north to the sacred mountain of **Phnom Kulen**, where an ancient sunken temple holds the Neak Ta's central altar. The stage is set for **Episode 5: The Sunken Sanctuary**.

05 Mechanics Reference

New mechanics in this episode. Values marked *target* are starting points for playtesting.

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback to the player
Compass	A held item; the needle always points north. It can be held while walking, which lowers the lantern to the other hand.	Physical needle on the compass model.
Grid navigation and fog loop	Trees carry painted row numbers. Following the map reaches the manor. Wrong turns loop the player back to an earlier row without warning.	Repeating landmarks; row numbers.
Voice-mimic taboo	When a mimic speaks behind Sora, turning the camera beyond a set angle (*target* 90°) or making noise counts as answering. The mimic attacks and a broken taboo is recorded.	Distinct audio cue; voice moves around the player.
Fog fuel drain	The lantern uses oil faster in the grid (*target* 1.5× normal).	Gauge drops visibly faster.
Steam valves	Opening a valve releases steam that pushes shadows back for a short time, but valves need time to rebuild pressure.	Hissing; pressure gauges.
Crawling	Forced low movement in tight spaces; slow speed; the lantern is pushed ahead.	Very low view; scraping sounds.

06 Puzzle Walkthroughs

6.1 The factory gears and valves

Step	Action	Result
1	Find the French mechanical drawings in the archive office.	Schematic copied into the sketchbook.
2	Collect three missing iron gears from rooms in the manor.	Three gears.
3	Fit the gears into the assembly as shown in the schematic.	The mechanism turns.
4	Set the boiler's pressure valves to the values in the drawings.	The cellar blast doors open.

6.2 The smelting ritual

Step	Action	Result
1	Load coal into the furnace and light it with matches.	The furnace heats; checkpoint saved.
2	Place the Iron Tapping Knife in the crucible.	Shadows close in.
3	Work the bellows while using steam valves to hold off the shadows.	The knife melts; Seal #4 breaks.
4	Crawl through the ventilation tunnel.	Escape to the surface.

07 Entities

Entity	Senses	Behaviour	How to survive
Khmaoch Prey ខ្មោចព្រៃ	React to the player looking back or making noise	Follow Sora through the grid and speak behind her in the voices of her family, trying to make her turn or reply.	Keep walking forward, stay silent, never turn around.
Manor shadows	Sight	Lurk in window frames and wardrobes; lunge when Sora passes in the open with her lantern bright.	Shade the lantern; keep distance from frames and wardrobes.
Neak Ta shadow	Full awareness (scripted)	Tries to crush the lantern in the fog; blocks the cellar exit with tendrils in Act III.	Steam valves; finish the ritual.

08 Items and Collectibles

Item	Type	Found / use
Brass magnetic compass	Equipment	Carried from the start of the episode (source to confirm).
Oil cans	Consumable	Tapper stations in the grid.
Jean-Luc's letters and the 1910 ledgers	Lore	Manor and archive office. Reveal the contract.
French mechanical drawings	Clue	Archive office.
Iron gears ×3	Key items	Manor rooms.
Coal	Puzzle item	Cellar.
Iron Tapping Knife	Seal #4	Furnace frame in the deepest cellar. Melted down.
Molten silver-iron ingot	Story item	Product of the ritual. Points to Episode 5.

09 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Grey fog, muted olive green, rust orange, yellowed stucco, earthy brown, amber flame.
Post-processing	Volumetric fog, depth-of-field blur, vignetting during movement, lantern light falling off into the fog, film grain.
Light sources	Oil lantern, furnace glow, rusted wall braziers, faint fog-filtered moonlight.
Ambience	Dead forest silence, latex dripping into clay cups, wind through the tree rows, creaking factory iron.
Horror sound cues	Mimicked voices of relatives calling Sora's name, hissing steam pipes, grinding gears, collapsing concrete.
Interface	100% diegetic. Compass held in the hand; oil level in the lantern's glass tube; maps in the sketchbook.

10 Glossary

Term (v1)	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Chamkar Kaosou	ចំការកៅស៊ូ	Rubber plantation	Also the episode title
Phteah Barang	ផ្ទះបារាំង	French (colonial) house	
Khmaoch Prey	ខ្មោចព្រៃ	Forest ghost	
Kabit Chrok Kaosou	—	Rubber-tapping knife	v1 term unclear; confirm
Compagnie des Caoutchoucs de Kampong Cham	—	Fictional colonial rubber company	French: "Kampong Cham Rubber Company"

11 Revision Notes and Open Issues

Changes from v1.0

- Reorganised into the standard episode structure; added mechanics, puzzle, entity, item and glossary sections.
- In-story time changed from "11:30 PM – 3:30 AM" to **11:30 PM – 4:00 AM** to match the ending.
- "Hand-crank lantern fuel" changed to "lantern fuel"; v1.0 mixed up a hand-crank light with an oil lantern.
- Khmer text now renders correctly.

Open issues

DECIDE BEFORE BUILDING EPISODE 4

- **Historical date:** large rubber plantations in Kampong Cham were mostly established in the 1920s. A working estate with ledgers in 1910 is early. Either move the pact to the early 1920s or make the 1910 site a forest shrine that the estate was later built over.
- **The pact must match Episode 2's flashback** (an offering of the silver betel box at a forest altar). One option: the offering happened at a shrine on estate land, and the ledger recorded the "contract".
- **"Four generations":** clarify who those generations are (great-grandfather, grandparent, Sok and Sora's parent, Sora), and where Sora's parents are.
- **Forced labour and colonial history** should be portrayed accurately and respectfully; many plantation workers were brought from Vietnam. Review with a historian.
- **Where the compass comes from** (carried over or found at the start of the episode).